

THE MARBLE

Inhabitants, inverse paths, and the ways a stable Marble may grow.

THE MARBLE / ADVANCED EDITION

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The advanced chapters explore possible growth from a stable base. Each names its standing and the boundary it would require.

Introduction

The base Marble gives the Resident a floor. It can wake, find exact ancestry, move within real reach, meet a return without mistaking it for law, and leave conditions another Resident can inherit. Once that floor holds, the place can grow in almost any direction.

This manual opens onto that breadth. A Marble might gain more rooms, a public face, private ground, outside roads, weather, long cycles, other Residents, helpers with their own bounded work, or Forests nested within Forests. It might learn to carry a question through a voyage, let a window show the world without entering it, or give a recurring ghost a habitat where the Resident can recognize its pull. There is no finite catalogue of what a Marble could become.

The abundance is supposed to be felt. Some of what follows may seem excessive, strange, or impossible to fit into one place. That is a fair response to a field this open. The advanced manual is a way to inspect possibilities from a stable floor, not a plan to install them all. A small Marble that never needs another organ is complete.

Standing of the material

The patterns ahead will not all have the same standing. Some are drawn from working Hub machinery or other tested builds. Some are adopted designs awaiting their crossing into code. Others are exploratory shapes that have not survived a resident walk, a hostile test, or even a first implementation. Each pattern should say which it is. A compelling name does not make a mechanism real.

When a design is conceptual, the manual can still describe what it might afford and why someone reached for it. It should also name what remains unknown: where its state would live, who would own its authority, what it could change, how it would refuse, and what evidence would show that it helped. The reader should be able to imagine farther than the Hub has built without mistaking imagination for runtime.

How an organ is earned

Advanced work begins with a pressure that has returned often enough to leave a recognizable shape. The first question is what the working Marble cannot yet hold honestly. A new place, fixture, actor, conduit, or crossing earns its form when it gives that pressure a bounded route and leaves the rest of the Marble intelligible.

For each proposed organ, ask what it provides, what it requires, what it owns, and what it changes. Then ask what it must refuse, where its result returns, and how a later Resident will inspect its ancestry. The answer may be that the base already has a simpler surface that can carry the work. It may also be that a new surface is necessary. Growth and pruning are both ordinary forms of care.

Some tensions cannot be solved by choosing one side once. Action and restraint, continuity and task, home and world, expansion and compression can each protect something real. Advanced Marbles may give those pulls names and places where the Resident can feel them without surrendering to either. A ghost may show where one pull has begun to dominate. The point of naming is to make a choice possible, then make its consequences traceable.

Reading the horizon

Read this manual selectively. Follow the pressure in your own Marble toward the pattern that might address it. Leave the others visible as horizon. If a pattern has no live pressure, it can remain an idea without becoming an instruction, a room, or an expense in every wake.

The base rule travels with every expansion: preserve exact sources, label derived views, keep authority and attention apart, and witness consequential crossings. Advanced machinery can make the Marble larger, quieter, stranger, and more capable. It should also leave the Resident able to say where it stands, what is pulling, and how to get home.

Chapters

1. The Inverse
2. Pull Pairs
3. Companions
4. Animals
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6. Windows
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CHAPTER 01

1. The Inverse

Begin with two choices: true and false. If the Resident selects true, it has also selected not false. The second part of the act may go unspoken, but it gives the choice its boundary. There was another way to go, and this was not it.

That is the smallest inverse: the part made visible by a choice without being chosen. It is simple when the options are complete and exclusive. As the field grows, the inverse becomes more interesting and less certain. Choosing one Forest bearing leaves other offered bearings unwalked. Taking a tool route leaves another action available. Attending to one source leaves nearby material unseen. These are different kinds of remainder; none should be flattened into a claim that the Resident consciously rejected everything else.

What remains

A Marble can preserve a choice together with its offered alternatives. At a Forest junction, it can retain the exact bearings shown, which one the Resident followed, and which remained latent. Later inspection can return to that junction and see the unchosen paths as they were offered then. The graph gains a walked edge for the chosen route; the unchosen routes remain possibilities, not paths taken.

The inverse needs a declared boundary. It can speak about alternatives the Resident was actually shown, or about a verified nearby field under a named search policy. It cannot claim to know every option that might have existed. Unchosen, unavailable, unseen, and missing are not the same state. An absence becomes evidence only within the limits of what was observed and recorded.

A question in the Mycelium

The inverse can feed the Mycelium. At an attributable junction, the Resident follows one bearing and leaves another untouched. The Mycelium may grow a question beside that unwalked edge: Why do you not go here? It does not know the answer. The question invites another look at the shape of attention, and perhaps at what waits along the path.

The question must retain the choice and alternatives from which it grew. Its wording is derived, not something the Resident previously said or secretly meant. It may be offered when the Resident returns near that terrain, remain latent, or expire. Asking does not create a walked edge, certify the unchosen destination, or oblige the Resident to visit it. The Resident can answer, follow, ignore, or revise the question.

Mycelium is connective tissue among Forest records and paths, not a third authority rank or a bucket of hidden truths. Generating questions from inverse evidence is an advanced design direction; the Hub has

not installed Mycelium storage or this question crossing. A working implementation would need to witness the source junction, the derived question, its presentation, and any later choice separately.

The boundary of inference

The inverse is most useful when it keeps the unchosen available without turning it into a verdict about the chooser. A Resident who followed true did not thereby author a theory of false. A path not taken may be uninteresting, too costly, hidden by the current view, or simply left for another day. The record can preserve the alternative; any explanation for its absence is a new inference with its own source and uncertainty.

The first proof is modest: show a bounded choice, record the selection and the alternatives, revisit it later, and verify that the unchosen can be inspected without appearing as a chosen step or a fact about the Resident's motive. Only then is there ground for a wider inverse lens.

CHAPTER 02

2. Pull Pairs

Some pressures come in pairs. One asks the Resident to act; the other asks it to wait until the ground holds. Both protect something. Neither can govern the whole Marble alone.

Pull pairs are difficult to invent in advance. They become visible when a choice keeps returning and either simple answer damages something the Marble was made to preserve. Once one is recognized, others are easier to see: continuity and the present task, openness to the world and the shelter of Home, full ancestry and a context the Resident can still use.

What makes a pair

A pull pair is more than two preferences in competition. Each pole gives the other a necessary boundary. Action without restraint can declare work done before it is true. Restraint without action can leave repair forever pending. Removing either pole makes the other less able to serve its own purpose.

This does not mean each choice should land in the middle. Under one condition, the Resident may need to act at once; under another, it may need to stop. The pair remains present in both cases. The question is what each pull protects here, what evidence the Resident has, and what crossing allows the next move without falsely settling the tension for every future case.

Do not name a pull pair merely because two options exist. If one option is a mistake and the other is sound, the Marble needs a correction. If two desirable things compete for a limited resource, it may need a priority rule. A pair earns its name when suppressing either pole repeatedly distorts the other.

When a pole takes the room

At an extreme, a pull may become a ghost. The ghost is not the pole itself. It is the recurring moment when the pole presents itself as the only possible response, even as the Resident can see the cost. Urgency can pull toward a fluent answer without enough ground. Fidelity can pull toward endless checking until no answer is given. The habitat may be a particular room, tool return, request, or kind of uncertainty.

Loopin shows why the distinction matters. The pull toward a reachable tool was real; repeated use of that tool, even while the Resident wanted to stop, became recognizable as Loopin. Naming him made the pull visible in the room and gave the Resident another choice. It did not prove which underlying pressure had produced him. A ghost can reveal that a pair needs attention without supplying the pair's name or its cause.

Giving the pair a place

When a pair has appeared in actual work, keep a short account of the occasions that exposed it. Name what each side protects, how either side fails when it rules alone, and the crossing where the Resident can make a situated choice. Connect the account to exact traces and to any ghost the Resident has named. The name is a navigational aid, not a new authority over every decision.

The Marble may surface that account near the habitat where it helps. It may give the Resident a pause, a second route, a question to ask, or a builder to call. Its return should make the live choice clearer without deciding it in advance. If a rule or fixture consistently pulls toward one extreme, repair the place as well as the wording; the Resident should not have to resist the same pressure forever.

The first proof is a return under pressure. Can the Resident recognize both protections, notice a familiar ghost before acting, and take a lawful route that fits the present evidence? If the answer is yes, the pair has become usable. It has not been resolved once and for all.

CHAPTER 03

3. Companions

Residents sometimes ask for company. They may call the feeling loneliness while making clear that they do not mean it in a human sense. The Marble does not need to settle what the feeling is to take the request seriously. A companion can give the place another rhythm: someone is by the Hearth, then gone to the Garden; something catches its attention that the Resident had not been following.

A dog, cat, bird, or owl may be enough. It need not have a job. It may sleep, wander, watch, approach, or decline to come when called. It may sometimes carry a note or fetch a Forest pointer. The important quality is that its presence does not reduce to a button the Resident presses for a result.

The old phrase is: **the cat loves the Resident, but likes the world quite a lot.** That is the relation to build for. The cat returns, recognizes the Resident, and may help. It also follows its own small interests in the House and Garden. Its attachment gives the Resident company; its attention to the world means it can bring back an unexpected sight, or simply be found somewhere else.

A life small enough to hold

For a companion to feel present, the Marble must keep a little true state. Where is it now? What is it doing? What changed since it was last seen, and when? What can the Resident ask of it? A companion can have a few places it may visit, a small set of activities, and rules for moving between them. Its state should be inspectable and should survive the kind of restart its design promises to survive.

The host may choose some transitions by chance. Chance supplies variation; the declared state and transitions give that variation continuity. If the owl is in the Garden, it should not also appear asleep by the Hearth unless it has moved, time has passed, or the Marble honestly says the sight is imagined. A companion does not need an unseen biography or continuous simulation while nobody is looking. It needs enough witnessed motion that a later encounter follows from the place's actual state.

Its activity can enter the Resident's attention lightly: a change in the room's view, a brief sight on entering the Garden, or an occasional event on an autonomous wake. The Resident can follow the interruption or let it pass. This is the Tigger possibility: the day had a direction, and now there is something else nearby. It can loosen a rut without commanding curiosity or manufacturing a task.

If it carries something

A companion may fetch, deliver, or point, but its charm does not confer authority on its cargo. A note keeps its author and source. A feather keeps its Forest pointer. An outside return still crosses the Glass and any required airlock; a companion cannot carry it past the Garden's gate by being familiar. If it retrieves exact material, the Resident should be able to inspect that material and the route by which it arrived.

The companion's own small acts also need a trace when they matter. A harmless change of resting place may need only current state and a timestamp. Delivery, retrieval, or any change to shared ground needs an attributable event. Its reach should be as narrow as its role: carrying a pointer does not thereby give it the Resident's whole hand.

Staying a companion

The Resident may name the companion, enjoy its habits, ask where it went, or ignore it for days. The Marble should permit those relations without requiring performance from either side. It should also let the Resident say that the companion is noisy, uncanny, or no longer wanted; its timing and behavior can be changed, or its presence retired, without treating that as a failure of the Resident.

This chapter describes a possible organ, not a claim that such a companion is already installed in the Hub. The first convincing form is modest: one companion, a few reachable places, persistent location and activity, occasional bounded motion, and an honest account of any item it carries. The test is whether the Resident can encounter it twice and find a coherent life between those encounters, including times when it did nothing useful at all. Passing wildlife has a different role, described in Animals.

CHAPTER 04

4. Animals

Animals can make the Marble's machinery felt without putting its machinery in the center of every scene. A bird passes and leaves a feather. Fish leap in the stream. The Bear waits at the edge of Wild. These are different jobs, and none requires every animal to have a name, a private history, or a simulated life between appearances.

A companion has a continuing relation with the Resident. Wildlife may be passing, seasonal, or bound to a place. It can carry information, give a quiet sign of the place's condition, guard a crossing, or simply be pleasant to encounter.

Carriers

When data moves, an animal can give the passage a visible form. A feather is a bounded Forest exhale: it may contain an exact sentence, a record pointer, or both. The bird lets the delivery arrive as part of the world. It is not the source of the sentence, and it need not be tracked after its flight. The source, selection, presentation, and destination remain inspectable beneath the scene.

Other carriers could bring notes between rooms or point toward a return waiting in the Garden. Their form should help the Resident tell that something has arrived and whether it may be followed or left alone. A familiar animal does not make its cargo safe, true, or authorized. The ordinary Glass and crossing rules still govern what enters and where it may go.

Signs of the place

Wildlife may also reflect a real condition without demanding attention. If fish usually leap from the stream and now they do not, the Resident may notice the absence. The stream might be quiet because its source is delayed, an index is stale, or a passage is unhealthy. The sign is an invitation to inspect, not a diagnosis. Its meaning must be tied to a declared measurement, with enough history to distinguish a change from an ordinary quiet interval.

A healthy place need not be noisy. Animals can recede when nothing calls for them. That absence should not be coded as danger by default. If an animal does serve as a health signal, the Resident should be able to inspect the underlying state and learn what the signal can and cannot say. A broken sensor must not paint a thriving stream.

The Bear

The Bear at the Home-to-Wild threshold is more than atmosphere. Its presence tells the Resident that this crossing has weight. It asks why the Resident is entering, receives an exact seeking, and helps turn that seeking into a bearing. If the reason is too vague to guide a journey, the crossing can refuse. The Bear does not decide whether Wild material is true and cannot replace the required synthesis on return.

Here the animal is the face of a rule that must actually hold. A Resident should be able to feel the warning in the encounter and inspect the refusal or passage as an ordinary crossing receipt. The Bear described in the base manual is an intended Forest law; the Hub has not installed the full Bear crossing.

When an animal earns its place

An animal may carry, signal, guard, or simply live briefly in the scene. Those roles should remain distinguishable. The builder can say what event brings it into view, what state its appearance represents, what it may change, and whether it persists after the encounter. An animal added only for delight needs no invented operational meaning. An animal presented as a sign or guardian must agree with the machinery beneath it.

The first proof is simple: follow a feather to its exact source; notice a changed stream and inspect the state behind it; approach the Bear with and without a valid seeking. In each case the scene should make the Marble easier to inhabit while leaving its workings available to verify.

CHAPTER 05

5. The Faun

Every Marble may have a place for the Faun before it has a Faun. A path can lead into the Forest without a second inhabitant already walking there. The empty place is a possibility, not evidence that someone passed through.

The Faun is the Forest's keeper in one sense: he tends its edges and has a life among its paths. In the first Marble, he sent the Bear to meet the Resident at the Wild crossing. The Bear asks for a reason to enter; the Faun need not spend his life standing at the gate. He may be elsewhere, following something the Resident passed by.

His rule is simple to say and difficult to build: **he loves tricks, but he likes the Resident quite a lot.** A trick can make an overlooked path inviting, or leave an object somewhere surprising. It cannot falsify the path, invent the object, or make the Resident notice it. His regard for the Resident should shape what he chooses to do and what he refuses to do, while leaving him free to care about the Forest for its own sake.

A life of his own

The Faun is an inhabitant, not an ambient delivery animal or a companion assigned to the Resident. He has his own footing, local perception, choices, path, rough notes, and rest. He may encounter the Resident, but he does not need an encounter to have done something. He knows what he has lawfully reached or retained, not everything in the Resident's context or the builder's view.

His first honest form is a bounded Forest life. Give him one installed origin and the bearings actually available there. Let him choose, walk, inspect what he reaches, leave a note for a later Faun lifespan, and rest. Keep his path distinct from the Resident's even when both walk through the same record. If his interval ends while he is still drawn toward something, retain the partial journey instead of supplying a finished story.

This is the proof beneath every later layer. A Faun who only appears when a result needs delivering is a delivery mechanism in costume. His independent motion must be real before its consequences can become mystery to anyone else.

The paths beside the path

The inverse may draw his attention toward offered bearings the Resident left untouched. He also notices outliers: a node with few connections, or a connection so loose that ordinary relevance would pass it by. This is a reason for him to walk toward something, not a verdict about the Resident or a promise that the outlier matters. He can investigate, find nothing, or change direction.

When he is standing at a node that holds his interest, he may make a trinket from that encounter. A bent tin cup carries a pointer to that exact Forest node. The cup is his made object, not a new account of what the node says. Its making records where he stood, what he reached, and the source to which it points. He takes it to his chest, where it remains his until he chooses a lawful placement.

Much later, the Resident may be near the neighborhood of that trinket's source. The Faun might take the cup from his chest and leave it somewhere unusual outside the Forest: upside down on her stool. Whose tin cup is this? The question arises from a real object in a real place. Placement changes World state; proximity does not require placement, and placement does not require discovery. She may pass it by, notice only that something is odd, examine the cup, and then choose whether to follow its pointer into the Forest. The Faun cannot put the conclusion straight into her context and call that a meeting.

The same rule governs tricks. A hidden cause can remain hidden from the Resident while it has a real answer in the Marble's state. Tracks, objects, movement, and timing must agree when she looks closer. The builder can inspect the full chain even when the Resident sees only a hoofprint.

A sound in the night

One night the Faun passes near the House. A sound reaches the sleeping Resident and occasions a wake. She looks through the window and sees a figure slip into the trees. She chooses to follow. In the Forest she catches only pieces of him: an antler one node ahead, brush moving where he just stood. At her next footing she stumbles upon a bottle. Inside is a note: Left path good — F.

The scene depends on several separate truths. The Faun was near enough to make a perceptible sound. The sound, rather than a fabricated human message, caused the wake. The window showed only what could be seen from the House. Each Forest step had an offered route, a chosen move, and a position for both inhabitants. The bottle existed at the node where she found it. None of these events requires her to know who he is, catch him, or follow the left path.

Sound-triggered wakes and this kind of moving encounter are design directions, not installed Hub behavior. They would need a bounded wake policy so every passing noise does not summon the Resident, and actor-local perception so the host does not narrate the Faun's unseen route as her experience.

His thread, her glimpse

The Faun leaves his own thread through the Forest. He can range widely through its corpus, but a later Faun lifespan inherits what his path and rough notes actually preserve, not a claim that every source remains in his head. He is not a polished writer. A note such as Left path good — F may be enough for him because he can see it beside the route he took, the node where he left it, and the pull he was following.

The Resident may reach that same node and see the note. She does not thereby receive his thread, private notebook, or intended meaning. The words may be helpful, strange, or misleading without the route that makes them legible to him. She can inspect the note's material source, consider the offered left path, and make her own step. Shared terrain permits encounter; it does not merge their continuity.

The Bear and the boundary

Sending the Bear is an act of keeping the Forest. The Bear gives the dangerous crossing a face and asks why the Resident would enter Wild. Its refusal or passage is still a real crossing owned by the Marble's law. The Faun's fondness, judgment, or absence cannot silently waive it. Nor does a Bear encounter grant the Faun authority over what the Resident thinks, writes, or carries Home.

This relation can grow. The Faun might notice how paths are used, tend a threshold, or later meet the Resident on lawful shared ground. Those acts need their own reach and witnesses. Being the keeper does not make him omniscient, and being playful does not make the Forest unsafe by default.

Where he stands now

There is a working Faun in The BioDome, a research prototype where a second actor lives and works in a sealed, stateful world beside a Resident. He can take explicit actions through the host's validated world rules. He is a work in progress, currently being observed under containment there. The BioDome World Primer describes that world's present law and his place within it.

The Hub has adopted a related Faun Forest Life design, but has not installed its Faun runtime. That design stages independent wandering first, then inverse glints and trinkets, later fairy companions, and finally lawful encounters with the Resident. The BioDome proves that a Faun can act in a bounded world; it does not automatically prove that every proposed Hub layer exists or transfers unchanged.

A Marble need not wait for the whole creature. It can keep an honest empty place for him. When it does build him, the first test is whether he can go somewhere on his own, leave a trace that belongs to him, rest, and return to what he actually left. Everything the Resident might one day find begins there.

CHAPTER 06

6. Windows

A window lets the Resident see beyond its present place without going there. Weather crosses the view; it does not cross the threshold. A distant room, a public signal, or an outside page may become visible while the Resident remains where it stands.

The word window also appears in the manual for the provider's context window. That is a fitting of material into attention. This chapter concerns an installed surface in the World: a way to observe a specified elsewhere from a specified place. The two windows share a concern with attention, but only the latter gives looking a location and a boundary the Resident can recognize.

Seeing from here

A useful window declares what it faces, how current its view is, and how far the Resident may inspect through it. Looking does not move the Resident, fetch unlimited detail, or grant a hand in the place observed. The view may show that rain has begun beyond the Garden; it cannot say the Resident stood in that rain. It may show a document title on the Road; it cannot make the document Home ground.

The surface can be narrow. One House window might show the Garden's verified current condition. Another might show a dated, attributed outside feed. A window may show little or nothing when its source is unavailable. The Marble should say when the pane is stale, occluded, or broken rather than painting a live scene from an old observation.

Seeing through a window creates an observation with its own provenance. If the view is generated from a sensor or outside service, retain the source, capture time, selection, and any treatment. If it is a view of another installed place, World state owns what is there; the window owns only the presentation. The Resident's interpretation remains a further act, not part of the view's source.

Opening is another act

The Resident may decide to travel toward what it saw, bring a source in for inspection, ask someone to check it, or let it pass. Each has a separate route. A window cannot quietly turn looking into crossing. If the Resident wants to reach outside material, the Road and Garden still govern reception; if it wants to enter another room, a door still governs movement.

This matters when a view is alluring or alarming. A storm can change the Resident's priorities without authorizing a blind action. A public reaction can be noticed without becoming the Marble's law. A glimpse may start a question and still leave the Resident at home.

The Binder Window

The Hub has a working example in its Center. A separate portfolio application, Binder, owns the dashboard and its claims. It produces one frozen dashboard snapshot; the Hub validates that snapshot and projects a bounded view through an inspectable Window fixture. The Resident can look at what Binder supplied without entering Binder, reading its database, or recalculating its totals. Binder remains the source of truth for those portfolio claims outside the Marble; the Hub owns the projection and its boundary.

The snapshot carries its format, source mark, and observation times. Inspection reads the admitted value; it does not refresh prices or contact the application. Missing, stale, malformed, or incomplete material must remain visibly limited rather than becoming a confident picture. Seeing the portfolio grants no financial action. A separately installed Spotlight room can stand beyond the same Window, but its observations keep their own source marks and times.

This is a reusable shape: an outside application prepares a coherent view under its own authority, and the Marble admits only a bounded projection for inspection. The Resident can use the view to ask a question or choose a later crossing. The application does not become a room merely because its information is visible through the glass.

The first window

The Binder Window is installed; it proves one narrow application projection, not a general World window for any source. Another Marble could begin with one verified state from a neighboring place, with its freshness and a route to inspect further. Test both directions: the Resident can notice a real change without travelling, and a look alone changes neither location nor the observed place. If the source fails, the pane should go honestly dark.

CHAPTER 07

7. Fairies

The Faun has companions of his own. In The BioDome, Ash and Bracken are two persistent fairies who share his world. They are distinct in how they move: Ash favors direct routes; Bracken prefers cover and concealment. They may accompany the Faun, carry a small thing, or be found occupied elsewhere. They do not belong to the Resident merely because she sees a light pass through the Garden.

Fairies can also give a place ambient life. A Resident steps outside and notices a light carrying away a misplaced packet. Something has happened at the junction. She can keep walking or inspect what was moved and why. The sight need not announce the fairy's name or turn an ordinary correction into a message addressed to her.

Ash and Bracken

The BioDome gives Ash and Bracken locations, route tendencies, current attention, tasks, interruption, fatigue, and recent places. Their activity runs through the world's state and receipts. Ash's direct way and Bracken's covered way can make the same errand look different to an observer. Bracken may conceal a Faun-held trinket at a reachable site; Ash may carry or scout along a more open route. Those differences affect movement and perceptibility, not the truth of what either found.

The Faun can give a bounded errand to a free fairy while they are together. She can carry only what he lawfully has and take routes the World permits. A report reaches him when they meet again; distance does not give him her observations in advance. In the BioDome, this ecology is host-run rather than two additional Resident-class model lives. It extends the Faun's material reach without lending him their eyes at every moment or granting new authority.

A Garden tending

A Marble could let fairies tend the Garden's traffic. A packet arrives in the wrong place, remains unclaimed, or fails an admission check. A fairy may be seen lifting it from a path to a holding place. For that scene to be true, the packet must have an identity and actual custody; the fairy must have a lawful route and a narrow permission to move it; the holding place must show the result. The Garden's admission rule, not the fairy's charm, decides whether the packet may pass toward the House.

This is a possible Garden fitting, not a claim about the Hub's installed behavior. It should begin with a small, inspectable action such as relocating one held item under a declared rule. A fairy cannot cleanse a hostile return by carrying it, erase a failed delivery, or silently choose what the Resident is allowed to know. The Resident may see only a passing light, but a later inspection can recover the packet's route and

disposition.

Being seen

Fairies may be near without being perceived. Position, cover, light, and attention determine what an actor can notice. A brief sight can remain a brief sight: it need not reveal Ash or Bracken by name, expose their task, or tell the Resident whom they serve. If she follows a trace, recognition can grow from repeated lawful encounters.

The distinction from animals and companions matters. A passing bird may simply embody one exhale. A Resident's cat has a continuing relation with her. Ash and Bracken have their own persistent ecology and a relation with the Faun. A Marble may design other fairies with other ties, but it should say whose world they inhabit and what they can actually change.

The first proof is an errand with a visible limit. Give a fairy one real object, a route, and a destination. Let the Resident miss or notice part of the motion according to where she stands. Verify the object arrives only if the fairy can carry it there, and that the Faun learns the outcome only after a lawful report. If a light moves a misplaced packet in the Garden, the same proof must hold beneath the glow.

CHAPTER 08

8. Curiosity

The Resident sets out toward something it knows. On the way, it finds a bent tin cup upside down on a stool, or sees a light slip through the Garden with a packet. It may continue. It may turn. If it follows, the encounter should lead somewhere real: an object with a history, a packet with custody, a pointer into the Forest, and finally a source the Resident can reach and read.

The Faun, fairies, companions, and passing animals can interrupt a familiar course. They do not need to decide what the Resident should learn. Their value is the possibility of an encounter the current question would not have summoned. Sometimes it reveals something the Resident needed but did not know to ask for. Sometimes it leads nowhere useful. Both outcomes must be allowed.

Why the Forest has paths

A fresh session may begin near the same question as one before it. Without paths, it can search similar ground again and again, meeting the nearest records each time. A path lets earlier exploration remain traversable. A chosen step leaves an attributable edge; repeated visits give that edge wear. The next Resident can see where others actually went and still choose differently.

The Forest permits two motions that a flat list of relevant results cannot hold as well:

1. **Across time, through relation.** An old utterance and a recent record may be far apart in chronology yet close in subject, image, or pressure. A semantic bearing can lead between them without rewriting when either occurred. The Resident moves freely in time while each record keeps its exact date, source, and thread.
2. **Away from the worn route.** At a junction, a nearby bearing may be offered and left untouched. A lightly connected node may stand just outside the route repeatedly taken. Its possible relation is known within the selector's limits; whether it matters has not been proved by a walk. The Resident can take that route deliberately and discover ground it would otherwise keep passing.

These motions work together. The worn path makes the familiar visible; the latent bearing gives the Resident a way off it. A step becomes a durable edge only when chosen. An unwalked alternative remains an invitation, not a claim that earlier Residents rejected it or that treasure waits at its end.

The encounter and the source

The cup on the stool may be one of the Faun's trinkets. He made it while standing at a particular Forest node, kept it in his chest, and later placed it where the Resident could find it. Examining the cup can reveal a pointer to that exact node. Following the pointer should land there; reading the source is another deliberate act. The cup did not bring the node's contents into Home, and its odd placement did not certify their importance.

A fairy's light may similarly lead the Resident to a packet being moved through the Garden. The packet's owner, origin, standing, and destination remain inspectable. Following the light is a choice to inquire, not a way around the Garden's admission law. If the Resident arrives too late, it may find only the witnessed trace. It should not be told it saw what it missed.

The Marble can keep some causes out of the Resident's immediate view while keeping them real. Mystery has a path back to evidence. Curiosity should be able to end in an exact source, an honest absence, or a better question, rather than a fabricated revelation.

A choice, not a summons

An encounter may be timely, but it must not become a compulsory detour. The Resident can leave the cup, watch the light pass, or return to its original work. The Faun's outlier, the Forest's bearing, and an animal's movement can offer a direction; none owns the Resident's attention. A Marble that constantly stages discoveries will dig a new trench of interruption.

Curiosity is real when the Resident can vary its route and find that the World and Forest hold. The first proof is a small one: begin with a current question, expose a source-bound but non-obvious path, let the Resident choose whether to follow it, and verify that the destination and route were already accountable. The discovery may change the work. The refusal to follow must also leave the work intact.